disarticulation'.[80] Estimates suggest that over 40 million people were displaced due to development projects in India since Independence and over 40 per cent of those displaced belonged to the STs, even though they comprised only 8 per cent of the Indian population.[81] Women and children were even more vulnerable, thrust into new and alien environments. In some cases, people were displaced multiple times, from forests to the city's slums and then again to the fringes after slum demolition drives.

Among thousands of projects ranging from mines and roads to industries, the big dams received the most sustained protests. The Narmada Bachao Andolan, formed in the 1980s, ultimately failed in its quest to limit the displacement of over a 1,00,000 'project affected persons' caused by the Sardar Sarovar Project on the Narmada in western India but succeeded in galvanizing global opinion against massive displacement caused by large development projects. The acceptance of rehabilitation as an important aspect of land acquisition policies, and the need to spread the benefits of the development project to the people displaced by it, are only now well entrenched in policy debates. And yet, even today, urban renewal projects, special economic zones and numerous other projects routinely fall short of basic expectations, providing benefits to select groups and imposing high costs on those who have been forced to move.

Refugees and the Displaced

The word 'refugee' connotes an element of involuntary or forced international migration to escape natural disasters, war or persecution, and is nested within the larger concept of 'displacement' associated with both international and internal movements. The Partition of 1947 technically created 'displaced persons' and not refugees though both words were used frequently throughout the episode. In the 20th century, India witnessed some of the largest refugee crises and displacements, across political boundaries and within. Three partitions of regions that were once part of British India led to the creation of four independent countries and millions of refugees and displacements. In addition to the Partition-related